

Proving God from the Armchair? Anselm, Gaunilo, and the Ontological Argument

An original lesson plan inspired by **Kenneth Himma & Graham Oppy's** the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* entry on *Ontological Arguments*. Not affiliated with or endorsed by *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* or *Kenneth Himma & Graham Oppy*. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/ontological-arguments/>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

DURATION

65 minutes

TOPICS

Philosophy of Religion

“Can we prove that a perfect being exists just by carefully thinking through the concept of perfection — or is existence not the kind of thing a definition can ever guarantee?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Anselm's ontological argument in premise form and Kant's objection that existence is not a "great-making" predicate.
- Apply Anselm's exact pattern of reasoning to Gaunilo's "perfect island" parody to test whether the parody succeeds against Anselm's argument for God specifically.
- Evaluate Plantinga's modal version of the ontological argument against the classical objections and defend a position on whether any version of the argument succeeds.

Materials Needed

- Handout with side-by-side texts: Anselm's Proslogion II argument, Gaunilo's island reply, and Kant's "100 thalers" objection
- Whiteboard for diagramming "possible worlds" for the modal version
- Small counters or tokens to represent possible worlds during the modal-argument activity
- Index cards for a closing gallery-walk vote

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Defining Perfection

8 min

Ask students to individually write a definition of "the greatest possible being" without using the word "God." Have a few share aloud and note, without commentary yet, that most definitions naturally include actually existing rather than merely being imagined — this observation is the seed of Anselm's argument.

Direct Instruction: Anselm's Argument

15 min

Walk through Anselm's core move: God is defined as "that than which nothing greater can be conceived"; a being that exists in reality is greater than a being that exists only in the mind; so if God existed only in the mind, we could conceive of a greater being — one that also exists in reality — which is contradictory; therefore God must exist in reality. Then present Kant's rebuttal: existence adds nothing to the concept of a thing, since a hundred real dollars contain no more content than a hundred imagined dollars — only existence, not conceptual content, differs.

Paired Activity: Testing with Parodies

18 min

In pairs, students apply Anselm's exact reasoning pattern to Gaunilo's "greatest possible island" and try to generate the conclusion that the perfect island must exist. Then discuss: is there a real disanalogy that blocks this parody for God but not for islands — for instance, is "greatest island" actually incoherent, since more beaches or coconuts could always be added, in a way that "greatest conceivable being" is not?

Direct Instruction and Discussion: The Modal Version

17 min

Briefly introduce Plantinga's modal ontological argument: a maximally great being that exists in some possible world exists necessarily, and so exists in all possible worlds, including the actual one. Focus discussion on the argument's most controversial premise — that it is even possible, or coherent, for a maximally great being to exist — and ask what work that premise is quietly doing.

Closure: Gallery Walk Verdicts

7 min

Students post an index card at one of three labeled stations — "argument succeeds," "fails on the island parody," or "fails on existence-as-predicate" — with one sentence of justification. Do a quick tally and highlight the spread of disagreement in the room.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Is Gaunilo's "perfect island" parody a genuine refutation of Anselm, or is there a real disanalogy between a "greatest island" (which seems incoherent, since more features could always be added) and a "greatest conceivable being" (whose perfection isn't tied to quantifiable features)?
- 2 If Kant is right that existence isn't a predicate or "great-making property," what does that do to Anselm's argument as a whole?
- 3 Does granting the modal argument's premise that a maximally great being is "possible" already concede most of what's actually in dispute?
- 4 Why might philosophers keep returning to reformulate the ontological argument — Anselm, Descartes, Leibniz, Gödel, Plantinga — rather than treating it as decisively refuted?
- 5 Can an argument be logically valid, with the conclusion truly following from the premises, and still fail to be persuasive? What would that mean for the ontological argument specifically?

Assessment

Students write a structured response walking through Anselm's argument premise-by-premise, applying Gaunilo's island parody to it, and stating whether the parody succeeds — ending with their own verdict on whether the ontological argument proves what it claims to. Grade on accurate premise reconstruction and genuine engagement with the parody, not the final verdict.

Extension Activity

Have students research one later variant of the ontological argument not covered in depth in class — Descartes's version in the Fifth Meditation, or Gödel's modal-logic version — and write a short summary of how it differs from Anselm's original.

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